

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

RAJASTHAN

Caustic Colours of Rajasthan

and temple officials frisked devotees to ensure they were not carrying any colours. For years, we have been celebrating Holi in part of the temple complex," alleged Congress leader and ex-minister Pratap S. Khachriawas.

Getting mud on the face on Holi may not be the best proof, but critics say the BJP is keeping the communal pot on simmer as the local body elections may be held later in the year. To be sure, the landscape is littered with evidence. The most egregious would be BJP legislator Gopal Sharma shouting "Pakistani, Pakistani" while Congress chief whip Rafeek Khan was speaking on an urban development issue in the assembly on March 8. Khan later broke down while speaking to the media about the incident. Close on the heels of Sharma was fellow party legislator Balmukund Acharya, who has been in high dudgeon about Muslims "evading the crackdown" against meat shops during Holi. His latest outburst was during a Holi celebration with lawyers where he asked them to use their "legal brains to bring an end to the azaan on loudspeaker" as it was giving him a headache.

> **"WE SHOULD BE CAREFUL IN OUR CHOICE OF WORDS... BUT PEOPLE ARE BEING OVERLY TOUCHY NOWADAYS"**
>
> **BHAJAN LAL SHARMA**
> Rajasthan CM

First-time chief minister Bhajan Lal Sharma has a task on his hands keeping his motormouth leaders in check. Critics now say that with these leaders showing little regret for their choice of words, there is a likelihood that the message will trickle down to the administration and masses that such actions are kosher. Already, an incident from March 2, where the baby of a Muslim couple was killed due to police 'carelessness' during a raid in Raghunathgarh village in Alwar, has led to an uproar and charges of high-handedness. It is alleged that the cops accidentally stepped on the baby when it fell on the floor. The authorities claim the raids were part of a statewide campaign against cyber criminals.

Rajasthan has so far avoided charges of being a communally polarised state. CM Bhajan Lal, who is just 15 months into power, will have to be on his toes if he and the BJP are not to sully that image by getting embroiled in unsavoury controversies. ■